Corbis for Academic Research

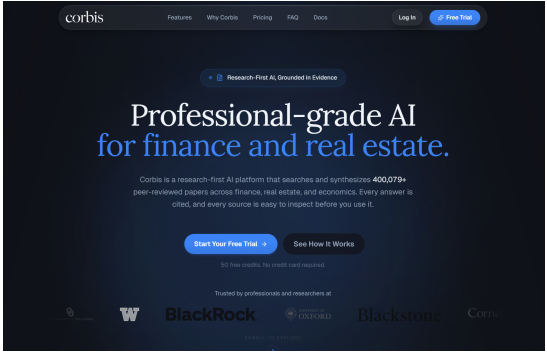
Getting started with Corbis and the Literature Starter Kit

Who this is for

Researchers who want to use AI assistants for literature reviews, idea screening, citation management, and a disciplined search trail.

Setup: Claude Code, Codex, or Cursor with Corbis MCP.

Goal: Leave with a first workflow and first prompts to run.



What Corbis Is

Research-grade AI tools

Corbis gives your AI assistant access to a curated academic corpus and returns results with citations you can inspect and verify.

Start with `search_papers`, `get_paper_details`, `top_cited_articles`, and `export_citations`.

What it provides via MCP

- Paper search, metadata, and citation export
- FRED macro data
- CRE market intelligence and dataset discovery
- Web search and deep research (select plans)

Why researchers should care

- Search the literature before making claims
- Trace where every piece of evidence came from
- Move from search to review to figures to writing in one repo

Why This Repository Exists

The problem

AI assistants are fluent but undisciplined: they skip searches, hide provenance, and leave no research trail.

What this kit adds

- 6 reusable research workflows
- Structured outputs in `notes/` and `output/`
- Automatic BibTeX export and LaTeX handoff
- Transparent search logging

What you gain

- Map a field in minutes, not days
- Screen ideas before committing weeks of work
- Keep a clean citation and writing pipeline
- Maintain a reproducible record of every search

What a New User Needs

Required

- A Corbis account
- A Corbis MCP API key
- An MCP-capable AI client

Recommended

- Claude Code for the smoothest slash-command flow
- Basic comfort with repo files
- Check citations before using them

Optional

- Python 3.10+ for figure generation
- LaTeX for manuscript drafting
- Codex or Cursor as alternative clients

Beginner rule

Always search before asserting novelty, importance, or data availability.

First-Time Setup in Claude Code

Step 1: Create the key

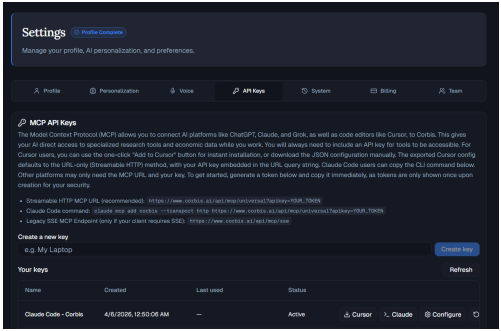
Open Corbis, go to **Settings** > **API Keys**, and create an MCP key. It starts with `corbis_mcp_` and is shown once.

Step 2: Connect Claude Code

```
claude mcp add corbis -transport http
https://www.corbis.ai/api/mcp/
universal?apikey=YOUR_KEY
```

Step 3: Work inside this repo

Clone the starter kit, open it in Claude Code, and run your first workflow: `/lit-review [your topic]`.



Other Client Paths

Codex

- Add Corbis to your `config.toml` (global or project-level)
- Set the MCP server URL and a bearer token env var
- Export your key, restart Codex, verify with `codex mcp list`
- Full guide: `CORBIS_MCP_CODEX_GUIDE.md`

Cursor

- Open **Settings** > **MCP Servers** > **Add**
- Name: `corbis`
- Paste the MCP endpoint URL with your API key
- Reload, then use workflow names as prompts
- Full guide: `CORBIS_CURSOR_PLUGIN.md`

All clients, same tools

Claude Code has the smoothest slash-command experience. Codex and Cursor use the same Corbis tools and the same workflow prompts from this repo.

Repository Map

Path	Why a beginner should care
`.claude/commands/`	Slash-command wrappers (`/lit-review`, `/idea`, etc.)
`.claude/skills/`	Workflow definitions behind each command
`.claude/agents/`	Paper-reader prompt for deep reading of key PDFs
`notes/`	Lab notebook and dated research decisions
`output/`	Reviews, idea cards, figures, `paper_set.json`, search log
`latex_template/`	Clean article template (`natbib` + `plainnat`)
`utils/`	Python figure generator for `/lit-landscape`
`references/`	Writing norms and citation formatting

How the Workflows Connect

Shared files

- `output/paper_set.json`: the canonical paper dataset reused across workflows
- `output/search_log.md`: a transparent record of what the assistant actually searched

The key idea

Run one workflow to build a literature base. Later workflows reuse it instead of searching from scratch.

Typical chain

1. `/lit-review [topic]` builds the paper set.
2. `/lit-landscape [topic]` turns that set into figures.
3. `/brainstorm [topic]` proposes ideas against the same literature.
4. `/idea [specific idea]` stress-tests one candidate.

Cross-client use

In Claude Code these are slash commands. In Codex or Cursor, use the same names and examples as prompt templates.

Skill 1: `/lit-review`

Use it when

You need to understand a field before pitching, writing, or designing a project.

Produces

- A synthesized review organized by theme
- A reading list of central papers
- BibTeX citations ready for your manuscript
- A reusable paper set for later workflows

Try it

`/lit-review climate risk and commercial real estate`

- Good first move for a seminar paper or dissertation scan
- Clusters papers by theme, not just by keyword
- Leaves you with a reusable paper set for the next workflow

Skill 2: `/lit-search`

Use it when

You already have a question or paper idea and need to locate the closest literature before claiming a contribution.

Produces

- Closest 3–5 papers
- A draft contribution paragraph
- A related-literature outline
- BibTeX export for cited papers

Try it

`/lit-search Do bank branch closures reduce small business lending?`

- Useful before a proposal meeting or referee response
- Searches by concentric rings: direct competitors, nearby methods, seminal work, recent papers
- Forces you to articulate how your paper differs

Skill 3: `/brainstorm`

Use it when

You know the broad area but not which question is worth pursuing.

Produces

- 10 ranked ideas from a wider candidate pool
- Expanded sketches for the top 3
- A recommendation for which idea to screen next

Try it

`/brainstorm behavioral biases in household mortgage decisions`

- Good for early-stage dissertation exploration
- Applies multiple idea-generation lenses, then checks novelty against Corbis
- Kills weak ideas before you become attached to them

Skill 4: /idea

Use it when

You have one concrete idea and want a hard-nosed screen, not encouragement.

Produces

- An Idea Card with scoring and closest papers
- Novelty verification against Corbis
- Stress tests and essential hurdles
- A Go, Revise, or Kill verdict

Try it

`/idea Do zoning reforms lower rent growth by changing landlord expectations?`

- Useful before spending weeks on data work
- Runs a desk-editor screen and three stress tests
- Identifies the hurdles you must clear and the exhibit you need

Skill 5: `/verify-citations`

Use it when

You have a LaTeX manuscript and want to audit whether every citation is real, complete, and correctly matched.

Produces

- A verification report
- Per-citation labels: OK, PARTIAL, MISMATCH, UNVERIFIED, or MISSING
- Checks against both the `.tex` and `.bib` files

Try it

`/verify-citations`

- Final pass before circulating or submitting
- Catches stale BibTeX entries copied across projects
- Reduces embarrassing citation errors

Skill 6: `/lit-landscape`

Use it when

You want figures that show trends, methods, and gaps in a literature.

Produces

- Publication timelines and citation landmark charts
- Journal distributions and method evolution
- Thematic heatmaps and coverage gap maps

Try it

`/lit-landscape corporate governance and firm performance`

- Useful for dissertations, review talks, or appendix figures
- Reuses `paper_set.json` when available
- Requires Python: `pip install -r requirements.txt`

Recommended Workflow

1. `/lit-review [topic]` to learn the field and build the paper set
2. `/brainstorm [topic]` to generate ideas, or `/lit-search [question]` to position an existing one
3. `/idea [specific idea]` to screen before committing to heavy work
4. `/lit-landscape [topic]` for visual evidence (talks, prospectus, appendix)
5. Draft with `output/` files and the `latex_template/`
6. `/verify-citations` before circulating

The discipline

Use Corbis to narrow the field. Use this repo to keep the search trail, outputs, and citations organized.

Outputs and Research Hygiene

What should stay in your repo

- `notes/lab_notebook.md` for dated research decisions
- `output/*.md` for reviews, memos, and idea cards
- `output/paper_set.json` and `output/search_log.md`
- `.bib` exports plus the LaTeX manuscript files

Corbis extras outside the repo

Research Insights gives journal-level corpus context. Open Datasets helps pair literature ideas with empirical data sources.

Why this matters

The repo gives you a search trail you can revisit, share, and reuse when the project evolves.

First Prompts to Try

Start with these three

1. `/lit-review climate risk and commercial real estate pricing`
2. `/brainstorm behavioral biases in household mortgage decisions`
3. `/idea Do bank branch closures reduce small business lending through relationship destruction?`

Docs to keep nearby

- `README.md`
- `SKILLS_USE_GUIDE.md`
- `CORBIS_MCP_CODEX_GUIDE.md`
- `CORBIS_MCP_TOOL_REFERENCE.md`

Remember

These workflows are not magic. They are a disciplined loop: search, synthesize, screen, document, verify.

corbis.ai www.corbis.ai/docs